PART I + FROM CHORES TO REAL WORK

Chores, Jobs & Work

Good habits around chores set the stage for responsibility, character, and lifelong success. Kids learn to contribute because they belong, then to earn because they have something to offer, then to work for someone who didn't have to choose them. Each stage prepares them for the next.

THE BIG IDEA

In proportion to the privileges we give our kids, we ought to give them responsibility.

Great privilege can lead to gratitude or to entitlement. What makes the difference is whether responsibility grows alongside it.

THREE STAGES, THREE DIFFERENT LESSONS

	1. Chores	2. Household Jobs	3. Outside Work
What it is	Unpaid. Required because you are part of this family.	Optional and paid. Extra work beyond the everyday chores.	Paid by someone else. Neighbors first, then a real job.
Tied to	Privileges, never pay	Pay, agreed on before the work starts	Pay and a growing reputation
What it teaches	Life requires contribution even when no one is paying you.	When you want more, work creates the chance to earn it.	Showing up, taking direction, and handling honest feedback.

I. Building a Great Plan for Chores

1. **Pick an accountability system.** A whiteboard, chore chart, stick jars, or a Skylight calendar. Kids should see what's due today and check it off themselves. The system is the reminder, not you.
2. **Name your privileges and consequences.** Decide the first three privileges that pause when a chore isn't done, in order, before you ever need them. Pick privileges your child actually cares about.
3. **Write a chores contract or plan.** On paper, so no one can say "you never told me."
4. **Hold a short, upbeat, and memorable family meeting.**
5. **Roll it out right away!** Start the same day. Give one week of grace while you work alongside them and show what "done" looks like. In week two, the system is fully in place.

A GOOD CHORES PLAN INCLUDES

- When chores are due (ours: 8:30 p.m.)
- What "done" looks like for each chore
- A positive attitude from kids **and parents**
- Guidelines for asking for help
- The three privileges that pause, in order
- What happens if a child argues: a second privilege pauses

HAVE A MEETING!

- Keep it short and keep it upbeat. Food helps.
- Have printouts of the plan for everyone.
- Frame it as shared ownership: "This home is ours, and we need you."
- Walk through responsibilities, deadlines, and privileges.
- Allow time for questions, not negotiation.
- Start right away!

II. Jobs in the Home and Work Outside the Home

As kids grow, encourage them to take on work beyond the home. It builds independence, responsibility, and an understanding of what money actually costs.

- **Keep chores and jobs separate.** If every chore is paid, kids opt out when birthday money arrives.
- **Agree on "done" and the pay before the job starts.** Mowing means front, back, edges, and sidewalk. Incomplete work earns incomplete pay.
- **Pay the same day,** and divide it into spend, save, and give that same day.
- **Outside work should pay more than in-home jobs.** That is what pulls kids out into the world.
- **Widen the circle step by step:** home, then friends and family, then the neighborhood, then a formal job.
- **Teach safety and preparedness** for each new situation.
- **If kids choose not to work, let them be bored.** Boredom is healthy.

> ***If you want something you don't have, and it isn't a need, you need to work for it.***

III. Getting a "Real" Job

- **During the school year, 15 hours a week or less.** Younger teens often do best with 5 to 10.
- **Summer is the jackpot.** More hours, a clear savings goal, and consider matching part of what they earn.
- **Choose jobs with real responsibility,** not standing around on a phone. Good first jobs have clear expectations, real supervision, and room to learn from mistakes.
- **Protect what matters most.** Family, school, commitments, sleep, and friendships come before work. Steer clear of late nights, highly adult settings, and jobs with long idle stretches.

IV. Be a Great Boss!

Model the kind of boss you'd want in your own life. Kids will remember how you led them.

Great bosses do	Great bosses don't
Make expectations clear and visible	Remind over and over
Let the system do the reminding	Threaten vaguely: "You'll be in trouble"
Follow through calmly, every time	Change the rules based on mood
Pay promptly and fairly for jobs	Enforce sometimes, but not always
Step back once the consequence is done	Take a missed chore personally

Sound like this: "The dishes weren't done by 8:30. A privilege is paused today, and the dishes still need to be finished." No lecture, no sigh.

V. Technology Boundaries

Chores go better with fewer distractions. Have a tech plan. Screens come after chores, not during them. Because tech is the privilege kids care about most, it is usually the first one to pause when chores are missed.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Fill this in before you leave, then take it to your family meeting.

Our accountability system: _____ **Chores are due by:** _____

Privileges that pause: **1.** _____ **2.** _____ **3.** _____

Our family meeting date: _____ **Who leads it:** _____